Minitel

Instructions on how to use a Minitel as a Linux terminal.

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2021-12-11

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1 Introduction

1.1 Contributing

Found an error or have a suggestion? Please open an issue on GitHub (github.com/pojntfx/minitel):

Figure 1: QR-Code to the source code on GitHub

1.2 License

This document and included source code is Free Culture/Free Software.

Figure 2: Badge of the AGPL-3.0 license

Minitel (c) 2021 Felix Pojtinger

SPDX-License-Identifier: AGPL-3.0

2 Compatible Minitels

Your Minitel needs to have a Funz or Fnct key and the DIN-5 port at the back side. This includes the following Minitels:

- Minitel 1B
- Minitel 2
- Alcatel ADF 258

3 Minitel DIN-5 to USB/RS232/Serial Adapter

To build the adapter to connect the Minitel to a PC, you need the following (cheap) components:

- 220 kΩ resistor
- 22 kΩ resistor
- 10 kΩ resistor
- 2N2222 transistor
- Male DIN-5 plug
- PL2303HX USB to UART TTL converter

You will need to check the pinout of the DIN-5 plug/cable; in my case, the following mapping is present:

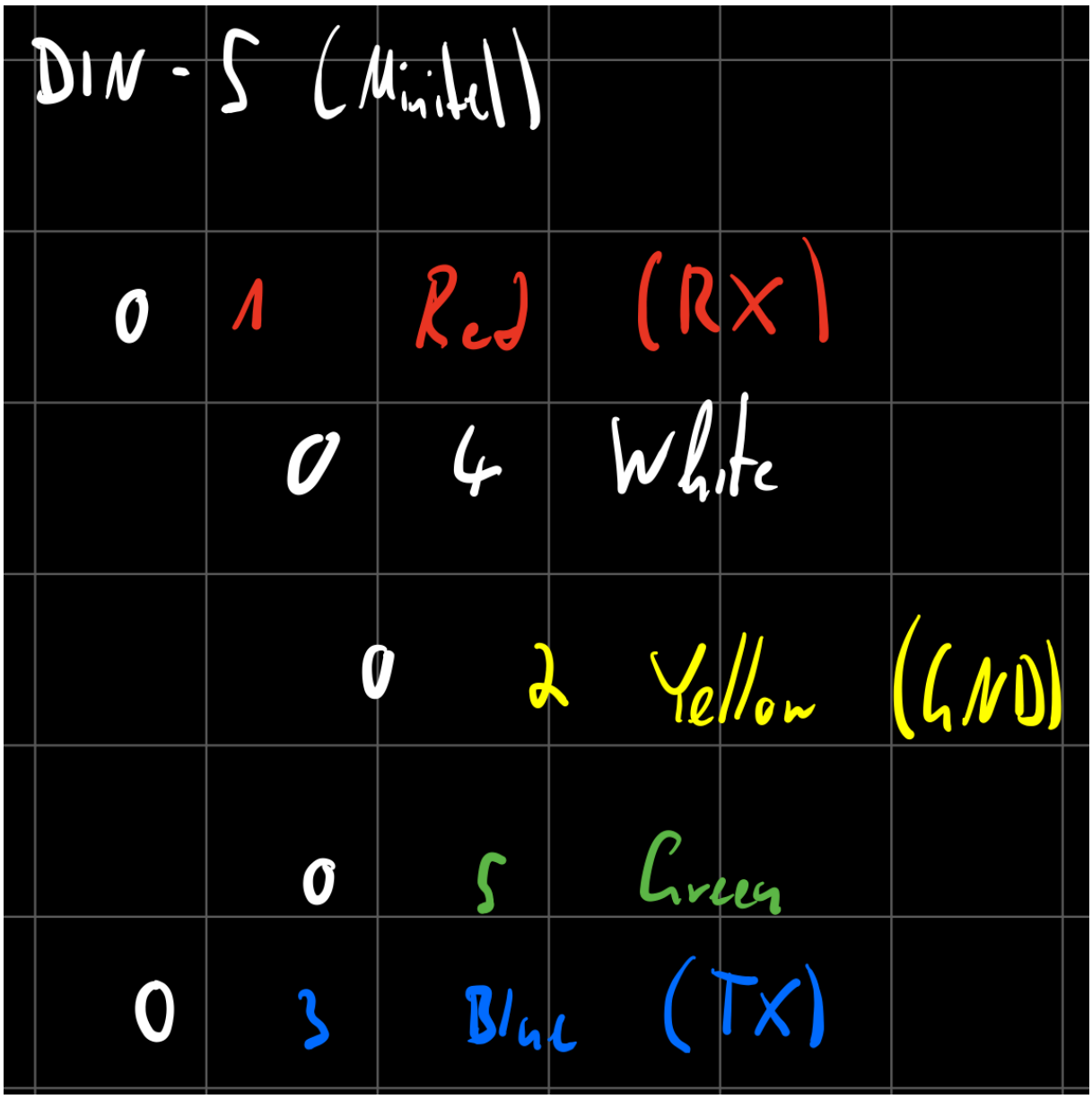

Figure 3: DIN-5 port mapping

Connect like so:

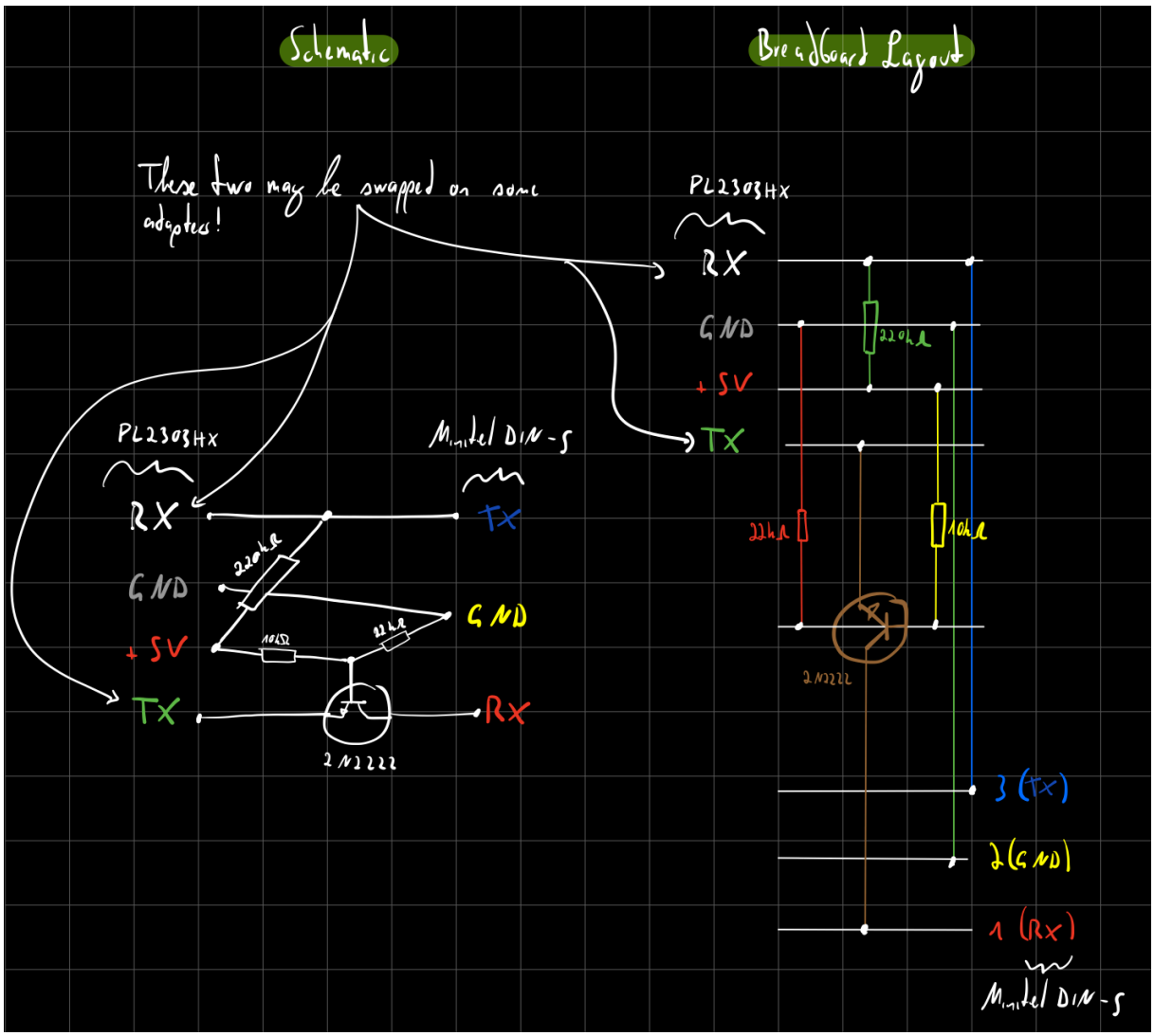

Figure 4: Schematic and breadboard layout

In my case, the breadboard prototype ended up looking like this:

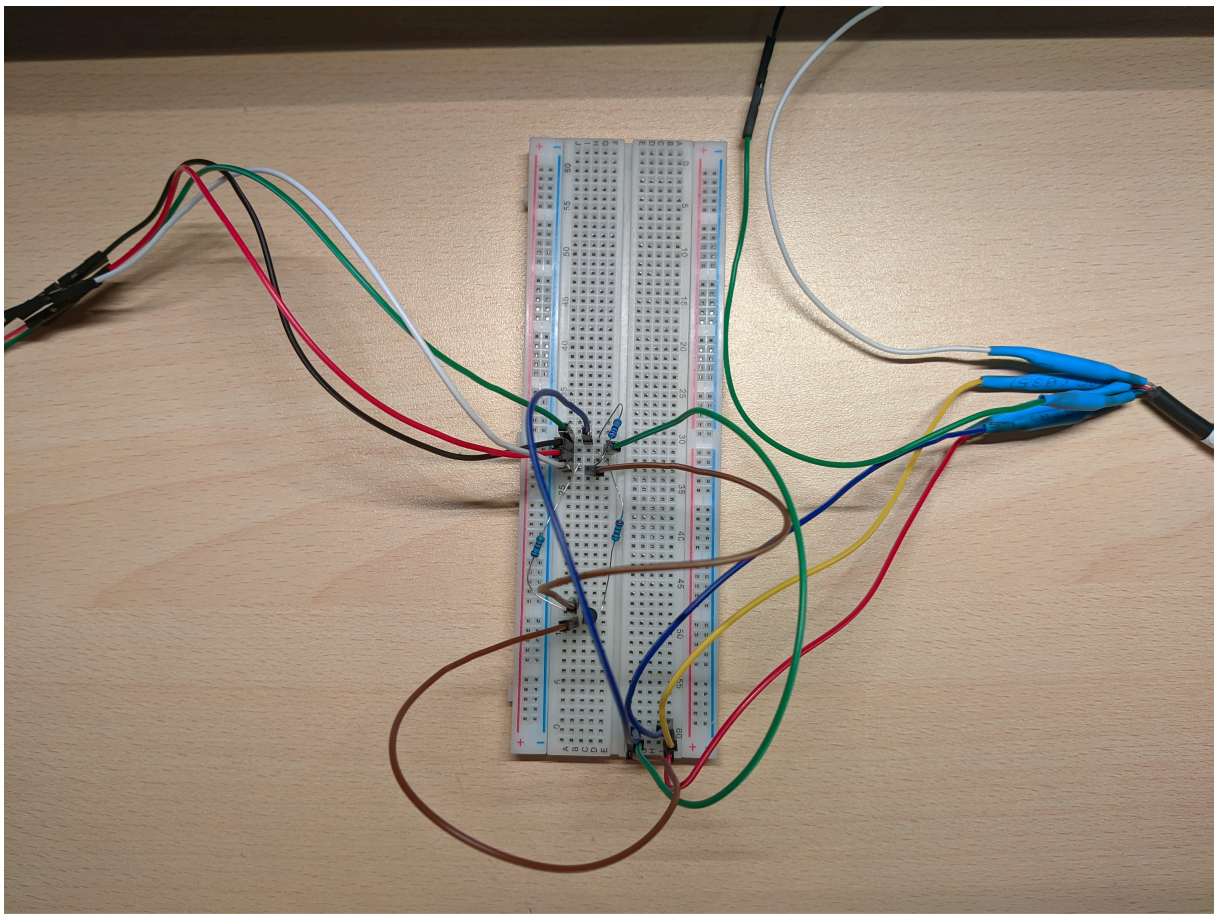

Figure 5: Breadboard prototype

I got this layout from Pila's blog.

4 Minitel Shortcuts

Minitel terminals show the integrated phonebook by default; for them to be usable serial terminals, use the following shortcuts:

French Minitel 1B/2:

1. Fnct + T A: Enables ASCII mode
2. Fnct + T E: Disables local echo
3. Fnct + P 4: Sets baud rate to 4800 Baud (the maximum)

More info can be found on Pila's blog.

Italian Minitel (Alcatel ADF 258):

1. Funz + Mem: Switches to terminal mode
2. Funz + M A: Enables ASCII mode
3. Funz + M E: Disables local echo
4. Funz + B 4: Sets baud rate to 4800 Baud (the maximum)

More info can be found on Retronomicon.